

A Guide to Applying to Graduate Schools

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To help navigate the grad school application process, we have assembled a guide with some best tips and practices for those preparing for grad school applications in I-O Psychology. These materials were created by Purdue I-O Psychology Alumnus, [Dr. Melissa Keith](#).

The guide covers the following topics:

- How to write a CV
- Personal statement
- Asking for letters of recommendation
- GRE 101
- Emailing faculty
- General timeline for applying to graduate school
- How to choose a graduate school program
- What is graduate school like?

We hope that this information will be helpful to you as you prepare and plan for graduate school! Good luck!

How to Write a CV

Curriculum Vitae:

- How is it different from a resume?
 - o CV's are typically specific to academic settings; Resumes are typically for jobs
 - o CV's can be lengthy, more detailed; Resumes are meant to be kept short and sweet

- What to include:

- o Name, Contact Information

Full name

Address

Phone: (xxx) xxx-xxxx

Email: email@school.edu

- o Education (GPA optional)

B.A. Saint Louis University - 2013

Major: Psychology

Minor: Business Administration

Overall GPA: 3.8

Psychology GPA: 3.97

- o Research Interests (*optional*)

- *Ideally there would be some correspondence between your stated research interests and those of the faculty at the graduate program to which you are applying.*

- *Can be bulleted:*

Creativity: Currently working on projects related to mood and creativity. Interested in a range of topics surrounding motivation and creativity including setting goals for creativity and understanding the impact intrinsic motivation and expertise has on the creative process and creative performance.

Motivation: Interested in applying goal setting to creativity and other domains of study.

Well-being: Would like to research topics related to employee well-being including how organizations could alleviate burnout - an ever increasing issue in our fast paced society.

- *Or in paragraph form:*

I have a few research interests that relate to motivation and creativity. In the future I hope to further my understanding of creativity and perhaps explore the impact expertise has on intrinsic motivation and ultimately creative performance. I am also

interested in goal setting and its effect on motivation. In addition, I am interested in how organizations could alleviate burnout, which I feel to be an ever increasing issue in our fast paced society.

- o Research Experience
 - Fall 2012-present Research Assistant, Training and Transfer
 - Conducted a literature search on training in organizations
 - Coded qualitative data
 - Helped edit a paper for publication
 - Fall 2010-Summer 2012 Research Assistant, Mood and Creativity
 - Coded qualitative data for a creativity study, assigning ratings for novelty and usefulness
 - Conducted experiments in the lab
 - Learned about the research and publication process
- o Presentations and Publications (*if any*)
 - It's ok if you don't have any at this point! Most applicants do not.
 - Make sure any citations are in APA format.
 - Examples:
Keith, M. G., Montag, T., & Rolwes, K. (under review). *Role of specific goals in creative problem solving*. Poster under review to be presented at the 28th annual meeting for Society for Industrial and Organizational Psychology, Houston, TX.
Keith, M. G., Baeza, M., Bertrand, J. & Montag, T. (2012). *Goal specificity and creativity*. Poster presented at the Saint Louis University Senior Legacy Symposium. Saint Louis, MO. (see Senior Legacy Award)
- o Applied Experience (*if any*)
 - *This could be an internship, applied project you worked on for a class, or anything related to I/O Psychology. Can also put work experience here, but more relevant is more ideal.*
 - Examples:
Summer 2012: Intern for X company. Worked with human resources to hire new sales agents.
Spring 2015: Training Facilitator for the Purdue University Quality of Work Environment Initiative focusing on leadership development. Acted as a role-player during the assessment, made ratings, and worked with management staff at Purdue University to develop leadership skills.
- o Awards and Honors
- o Community Service
- o Extra curricular

- o Affiliations (*if any*)
 - E.g., SIOP, APA, APS
- Other Information
 - o Don't include past work experience *unless it is relevant to the field*.
 - o If you have leadership experience, try to fit that in somewhere.
 - o Do not include anything from High School.

Tips for Writing Your Personal Statement

- Primary Purposes:
 - o This is different from the personal narrative written when applying to your undergraduate institution in that it isn't about a personal hardship you faced or about something you experienced in high school that shaped you as a person.
 - o Show that you know why you want to get your Masters/PhD at that school.
 - o Highlight your research interests (that hopefully match the faculty at that school) and your relevant experiences in college.
 - o Provide information about who you are.
- General Advice
 - o Be efficient, be specific, and don't waste words.
 - o Try not to be too cliché.
 - Examples of cliché openings:
 - "One day I just knew I wanted to pursue a degree in Psychology..."
 - "I want to go into psychology to help people."
 - o If possible, tell a story about why you want to go into this field.
 - o Make sure your paper flows and is not disconnected (e.g., make sure your opening paragraph makes sense with your other paragraphs).
 - o Be informed about the program. Make it clear about how you would fit into the program and how you would contribute.
 - o If you are interested in working with a particular faculty member (or two, or three) be sure to mention them by name! Explain why you would be interested in working with them.
 - o Strike a balance between confidence and overconfidence.
 - o Don't wait till the last second to write your Statement. Start the summer before your senior year if possible.
 - o Proof read your statement carefully AND have multiple people read it (ideally those who have agreed to write you a letter of recommendation).
- Other Resources:
 - o <https://owl.english.purdue.edu/owl/resource/642/01/>
 - o <http://www.cws.illinois.edu/workshop/writers/tips/personalstatement/>

Asking for Letters of Recommendation

Who should I ask?

Typically, graduate programs are looking for *academic* references. Thus, you should be identifying professors who could write you a good letter of recommendation. You can obtain good letters of recommendation by getting involved in research, getting to know your professors, and demonstrating reliability and good work ethic.

If nonacademic references are permitted, I suggest asking someone working in a relevant field. A family friend of high school sports coach is probably not the best option.

When should I ask?

Depending on when the applications are due, asking in September or October should be safe. Your recommender should ideally be given a month's notice to allow time to formulate a decent letter (it is also just common courtesy).

If you are asking far in advance, be sure to remind your recommenders as the deadline approaches. Faculty sometimes get busy and forget, so feel free to send them a gentle reminder if a deadline is approaching and no letter from them has been submitted.

How should I ask?

Many sources suggest asking in person. Email the professor to set up a meeting to discuss graduate school and use that time to ask whether they could write you a *strong* letter of recommendation. Gauge their reaction, and if the answer is no, do not take it personally - be grateful that they answered honestly.

I suggest also using that meeting to discuss your graduate school plans (allows the professor to get a better idea of who are and what your goals are). Be sure to articulate why you want to go to graduate school. You can also ask questions and seek advice about different programs you are thinking about. Don't be afraid to pick their brains a bit!

If this is a professor you have only had in class, be sure to include a little background information (e.g., which class you had with them and when). This will allow them to easily look you up and jog their memory a bit about who you are.

*Note: It is also ok to simply request a letter of recommendation over email if a meeting is not possible.

What materials should I give my requestors?

1. A copy of your CV/Resume
2. A copy of your Personal Statement
3. A table of schools, deadlines, how the letters are submitted (mail or online) *Note: Almost all letters are now submitted online through a submission system or via

email. After you submit an application, your recommenders will receive an email to submit a letter.

4. If there are letters that need to be mailed in, have stamped and addressed envelopes prepared
5. A good writing sample (*optional*)

Should I waive my right to read the letter of recommendation?

Yes, generally it is better if you do. Many professors would feel uncomfortable writing an open letter and graduate schools are more suspicious of open letters. Know that it is very rare for a faculty member to write anything negative about someone!

Should I write a thank you note?

Absolutely! Also be sure to update your recommenders when you accept an offer from a graduate program. Even a quick email thanking them for their time is much appreciated.

GRE 101

Last updated: May 2022

Frequently asked questions:

1. When should I take the GRE?
 - Ideally, the summer before your senior year. Take the summer to study and take in late July. This will allow you to take it again if need be.
 - Be sure to sign up for the test at least a month in advance. The testing centers fill up.
 - See for centers/dates:
https://www.ets.org/gre/revised_general/register/centers_dates
2. How much does the test cost?
 - \$205 as of May 2022
 - *Note:* There is a [GRE Fee Reduction program](#) that allows you to pay \$102.50 (i.e., 50% of the regular test fee). You will also receive free access to some GRE test preparation materials.
 - Eligibility:
 - o US citizen
 - o College senior or college graduate not currently enrolled in any classes
 - o Attending undergraduate program in US or US territories
 - o Must receive financial aid through your school and either be a dependent who has an Institutional Student Information Report (ISIR) that shows your parental contribution is not more than \$2500 for the senior year or be self-supporting and have an ISIR that shows a personal contribution of less than \$3000 for the senior year.
 - o If unenrolled graduate, must have applied for financial aid and have an ISIR that indicates you are self-supporting and have a contribution of not more than \$3000.
3. How long is the test?
 - About 4 hours - Three separate timed sections: Verbal Reasoning (2, 30-minute sections, with 20 questions each); Quantitative Reasoning (2, 35-minute sections, each containing 20 questions); and Analytic Writing (1 section with two separately timed tasks: "Analyze an Issue" and "Analyze an Argument")
 - *Note:* May also be required to complete an unidentified and unsecured section for testing purposes.
4. When will I get my score?
 - Same day, but you will receive your writing score and percentile scores later.

5. Should I send my scores to schools at the end?
 - The GRE lets you send your scores to a certain # of schools before you see your score (note that this may have changed!). I think it is risky, but on the positive side it will save you money. It costs about \$27 to send scores (multiply that by the schools you are applying to, and you see what a rip of the whole thing is!). Whether or not you send your scores is up to you, but I chose not to.
6. What is considered a “good score”?
 - The test is scored from 130-170. What is considered a good score will depend on what the graduate schools are looking at (see Question 10), but in general you will want to get above the 60th percentile in both verbal and quantitative reasoning. That would mean a score of 153 in verbal reasoning, 156 quantitative reasoning, and above a 4.0 (out of 6.0) on the Analytical Writing. Obviously, though, the higher the better.
 - To get a *perfect* score on the Verbal you can miss 0-1 questions, but cannot miss any on the Quantitative section.
7. Should I take the Psychology subject test?
 - Your call, but I would not suggest it unless it is required. No need to study for an unnecessary test.
8. What is the best test prep?
 - There are three main options: a) Take a test prep class; b) Use an online test-prep program (e.g., prepscholar) c) Self-study using a test prep book.
 - The prep classes are expensive (< \$1000), and the study books you can order on Amazon for about \$15-35. ETS also has some online options that are free or less expensive (see “Test Preparation” https://www.ets.org/gre/revised_general/register/fees/). If you are the type of person who can be self motivated, skip the class. The books can prepare you just as well as a class *if* you are willing to be disciplined. I suggest going through the Kaplan, ETS, or Princeton Review test prep books and taking plenty of practice tests.
 - Alternatively, you can do the in-between option and study autonomously but with the guidance of an online study program. This will provide you with some structure, but generally be much cheaper than a prep class. Caution: not all the online preps use the actual GRE materials made by ETS! I recommend POWERPREP Online because it uses the ETS materials (https://www.ets.org/gre/revised_general/prepare/powerprep/) and has some versions for free.
9. How often can I take the GRE?
 - Every 21 days and up to 5 times in a year (12 month period)
10. How heavily will my GRE be weighted by graduate schools?
 - The answer to this question depends on the field, school, and program you are applying to. In general, it is a cut-off score (e.g., > 30th percentile; > 50th

percentile). Applicants above the desired score will be considered before other students below the desired score. Programs will often post their average or desired score on the application webpage.

- If your GPA is lower than other applicants or you don't have as much research experience, having a high GRE score can be very helpful in demonstrating your potential.

11. Are all schools requiring the GRE? Should I only apply to graduate programs that don't require the GRE?

- Most of the top graduate programs in IO Psychology understand the value of the GRE for predicting graduate student success. Limiting yourself to only graduate programs that do not require the GRE will be limiting your options.

For other frequently asked questions: https://www.ets.org/gre/revised_general/faq/

General tips:

- Learning *how* to take the test is at least as important as learning the material potentially on the test. (e.g., <https://www.kaptest.com/study/gre/top-8-tips-to-ace-the-gre/>)
- Put in the study time! Estimates of about how long it takes to get total point increases:
 - 5 points = 40 hours
 - 10 points = 80 hours
 - 20 points = 160 hours
 - 30 points = 240 hours
 - For a 2-month study plan see: <https://www.kaptest.com/study/gre/how-to-study-for-the-gre-in-two-months/>
- Target your weakest/most difficult sections. This is where you will see the biggest gains.
- Taking lots of *timed* practice tests is a must (see Helpful Websites). Try to take the test under comparable conditions (e.g., same time, one sitting).
- Schedule your test at a time you feel you can be most focused (e.g., don't schedule a morning test if you are not usually an early riser).
- Read over the list of restricted items (https://www.ets.org/gre/revised_general/test_day/) and what to bring the day of.
- The day of, you will need to bring your test confirmation receipt and a photo. See website for any additional, location specific requirements.
- You cannot use your own calculator, so practice using the computer provided one.
- Prepare for the temperature in the testing room - dress in layers!
- Don't drink too much caffeine. You will be jittery and/or will have to go to the bathroom a lot.
- The GRE environment is strange. There is fingerprinting/hand scanning and you are heavily monitored. Just be aware that it isn't the most "normal" environment.

- The written section comes first. In general, longer essays receive higher scores...
Other Tips: <https://www.kaptest.com/study/gre/7-tips-for-a-perfect-gre-issue-essay/>
 - Written test is not as important as the other two sections - just needs to be high enough not to raise red flags.
- The GRE is an adaptive test. Everyone gets the same first section of the verbal/quantitative and that will determine the difficulty of the second verbal/quantitative section. Be sure to do well on the first sections of the test and do not rush through. How you do at the beginning of the test will determine your upper threshold score. If you get to the end of the problems and feel it is incredibly hard, don't panic - you probably did very well!
- Manage your time.
- Can skip questions and come back to them, but you get more points for getting harder questions.
- At the end of the test, you will be given the option of reporting or canceling your scores. Do not cancel your scores! You have the option of selecting which score (if you take it more than once) that you report.
- Keep calm, it is just a test. You can always take it again, and what you are doing now (aka getting involved in research) counts for a lot of graduate school brownie points.

Helpful websites:

https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCetxnoJKtzoT9ye9UVS_VbA

https://www.ets.org/gre/revised_general/prepare/

https://www.ets.org/gre/revised_general/test_day/

<https://www.manhattanprep.com/gre/resources/>

<https://quizlet.com/subject/gre/>

http://www.ets.org/gre/revised_general/prepare/powerprep2

Emailing Faculty

Some give the advice to email faculty in advance of applying to their program to introduce yourself, ask if they are taking graduate students, ask questions, and possibly set up a meeting to discuss the graduate program. As a faculty member, I find this to be unnecessary and bordering on problematic depending on how it is done. Here are some dos and don'ts to help avoid common pitfalls that I now see regularly as a professor. Please know, however, that these are *my* opinions and the opinions of those in my academic circles and may not be shared by all faculty at all graduate programs.

- **Do not...** email faculty asking questions that can easily be located on the program's webpage.
- **Do not...** email faculty requesting a meeting to discuss the program (faculty may differ on this point, but seems like more risk than reward). The reason I do not accept meetings with potential graduate students is threefold: 1) There are often several requests for meetings such as this every semester, which would equate to a lot of time spent on students that my program may or may not accept into the program. It is important to me to focus my attention on my current graduate and undergraduate students. 2) Unstructured meetings such as this may introduce bias into the process. Thus, having a policy of not scheduling meetings with potential applicants or applicants makes the admissions process fairer and more standardized (less biased) across applicants. 3) Students accepted into our program (and many others) are invited to a visitation weekend for students to gauge fit and ask important questions.
- **Do not...** email faculty asking about your chances of "getting in" to the program. We cannot give you that sort of estimate without reviewing the applications.
- **DO...** email faculty to ask if there is a graduate student they recommend reaching out to for more information about what it is like to be a graduate student in the program. *Note: This may be more appropriate after being accepted into the program unless you are deciding whether or not to apply.
- **DO...** email faculty you may be interested in working with to see if they are planning on accepting graduate students. Faculty and even entire graduate programs may not take new students every year. Sending a short email introducing yourself, stating that you are interested in the program, and asking if the faculty and/or program will be taking graduate students in Fall 20XX is appropriate and may save you an application fee if the answer is no.
- **DO...** email faculty to ask questions about the program *that cannot be found on the program's webpage*. Most faculty are happy to answer questions and share information about the program!

In general, do not feel like you *need* to email faculty at the programs you plan to apply to. We generally do not remember who did and did not email us, so there is no real benefit to doing so unless you have legitimate questions.

General Timeline for Applying to Graduate Schools

Freshman - Junior Year:

- Get involved in research - the sooner the better!
- Start thinking about the program in Psychology (or other field) you would like to specialize in.
 - There are many options: I/O, Social, Clinical, Counseling, Cognitive, Quantitative, Developmental, etc.
 - When deciding, think about what type of research interests you. (Good reason to get involved in research)
 - It is ok to do research in areas that you don't plan to attend graduate school in! Not all undergraduate institutions have an I/O program, and that is ok.
- Get to know the faculty and graduate students of the field you plan to pursue a graduate degree in if there is an I/O program. If you are coming from a school without an I/O program, connect with the faculty and/or graduate students at your institution.

Junior Year:

- Begin researching potential schools (<http://hml.louistay.com/iopsych?p=how>)
 - Current graduate students can be an excellent resource
 - Some fields have searchable databases (e.g., <https://www.siop.org/Events-Education/Graduate-Training-Program>)
 - Who are the faculty?
 - Is the program applied, academic, or both?
 - What is the program's reputation? (can ask faculty and/or students about this; can also look at various rankings online)
 - Are they doing research you are interested in? (can look at faculty web pages or Google Scholar to find recent research)
 - Is it a mentorship model (working under a particular faculty member) or do students work with multiple faculty?
 - Are the faculty members publishing?
 - Are the graduate students publishing?
 - What are the outcomes for graduate students? Are they getting good job placements?
 - What are the requirements to be accepted?
- Study for the GRE or at least develop a plan to study for the GRE

Summer before Senior Year:

- Study for the GRE

- Take the GRE
- Start getting application materials together
 - Decide who will be writing letters of recommendation (usually need 3)
 - Personal Statement
 - Transcripts
 - Curriculum Vitae (CV)/Resume

September of Senior Year:

- Work on your personal statement
- Start filling out applications
- Figure out when applications are due

October of Senior Year:

- Have credible people read over your personal statement and CV
- Finalize your CV/Resume
- Request letters of recommendation
- Retake GRE (if necessary)

November-December of Senior Year:

- Send in GRE scores
- Send in Transcripts
- Check on the progress of your letters of recommendation
- Finish applications

Keep a spreadsheet of...

School	Deadline	Required Materials	Letter of Rec	Application status
Purdue	Jan. 1	• CV • GRE • writing sample • transcript • personal statement • Letters of rec (3)	electronic	application in progress
BGSU	Dec. 20	• CV • GRE • transcript • personal statement • Letters of rec (3)	electronic	complete
UT	Nov. 25	• CV • GRE • transcript	Letter <Address.	need to send: letters of rec

		• birth certificate • personal statement • Letters of rec (3)		
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*Information in this chart is for demonstration purposes only.

How to Choose a Graduate School Program

1. Good faculty.
 - Sooo important!
 - Graduate programs are essentially apprenticeships, so the faculty need to be people you can work with and who will help you develop (i.e., learn the skills you need) and be productive (i.e., publish).
 - You should be interested in what the faculty is researching.
 - Think about your level of independence. More than likely you will want someone who has bandwidth to spend time meeting with you on a regular basis.
 - You will need to learn to work with your advisor. They will have a particular mentoring style and it is your job to learn to work with that style.
 - Talk to past and current graduate students about what the faculty is like.
 - *Questions to ask:*
 - o Faculty: What is your mentoring style?
 - o Faculty: What sort of projects would I be working on?
 - o Faculty: What would my role be as a graduate student in your lab?
 - o Faculty/Graduate Students: Will I have opportunities to publish?
 - o Graduate Students: What is Dr. X like to work with?
2. Good fit with your working style, needs, and interests.
 - Fit will be based on your ability to be productive with the faculty at that school. This is highly dependent on the research interests of the faculty, the mentoring style of the faculty, and the mentorship model in that program.
 - Best Athlete vs. Mentorship Model
 - o Best Athlete Model: graduate students do not work with a particular advisor and compete for resources and projects.
 - Good if you like competition, are fairly competent (perhaps already have a Master's degree), and prefer independence.
 - o Mentorship (or Apprenticeship) Model: graduate students are paired with a faculty member and are mentored primarily by that faculty member.
 - Generally good for everyone (in my opinion)
 - Fit is based on your fit with an individual faculty member.
 - o *Note:* These two models are often on a continuum. Some programs are more open (have an advisor, but also are encouraged to work with other faculty as well).
 - Positive/collaborative culture
 - o Difficult to ascertain from just looking at a website, so if you have the opportunity to visit that is preferable. If you cannot visit, it is completely fine to email current graduate students to ask questions about the program.
 - o Programs differ on their degree of power distance between faculty and graduate students. Some programs are very laid back with students and faculty interacting more like colleagues and other programs are highly formal with

graduate students calling the faculty Dr. so-and-so. Both can be very positive, but get to know the norms of the program before being overly casual in emails to a faculty member.

- *Questions to ask:*
 - o Faculty/Graduate Students: What is the culture of this program?
 - o Graduate Students: Do the graduate students get along?
 - o Yourself: Was the atmosphere positive or do the graduate students complain a lot?
 - o Faculty/Graduate Students: Do the graduate students have collaborations (work on projects) with each other?

4. Resources available to graduate students.

- *Questions to ask (some best asked AFTER offer is received):*
 - o Faculty/Graduate Students: What types of funding are available?
 - o Faculty: Do graduate students typically get funded for the full 5 years or more?
 - o Graduate Students: Do the graduate students have a place to work (office)?
 - o Faculty: Do graduate students have funding for conferences and external training?
 - o Graduate Students: Do graduate students have access to expensive equipment/software (e.g., computers, statistical software)?
 - o Graduate Students: What is the cost of living like in this area?

5. Favorable job placement.

- The ultimate goal of going to graduate school is being able to get a job after graduating.
- Choose your program and discipline wisely.
- Decide what job(s) you would like to have and seek programs/disciplines that will help you get there.
- *Questions to ask:*
 - o What is the job outlook in general?
 - o Will a postdoc be expected or necessary? What are the benefits of a postdoc?
 - o What jobs do graduate students usually get after graduating?
 - o What is the starting salary for the typical students leaving the program?

6. Location.

- Don't apply based on 'where would be exciting to live for the next couple of years.'
- You are too busy/poor in graduate school to take full advantage of living in a city.
- Many of the best graduate programs are in less exciting college towns (e.g., West Lafayette, Bowling Green, Urbana-Champaign, East Lansing, Akron)
- Should consider the cost of living and possibly safety.
- *Questions to ask:*
 - o Graduate Students: What is the cost of living/rent in this location?
 - o Graduate Students: Where do the graduate students typically live?
 - o Graduate Students: Do graduate students feel like they have enough to live on?
 - o Graduate Students: Do graduate students typically have to take out additional loans?

What is Graduate School Like?

What to expect when you go to graduate school...

1. Doing well in classes is important for demonstrating competence, but not at the expense of doing well in other areas such as research or degree progress.
 - Graduate school is not about making an A on a test (assuming your graduate program even has tests).
 - Need to obtain the knowledge, skills, and abilities necessary for your future job. If you cannot apply what you have been learning, the classes are not useful.
 - With that said... demonstrating competence to the faculty is important. Faculty are often more interested in working with students they notice doing well in classes.
 - Also... a C is usually considered failing in graduate school.
2. You will work more than 40 hours per week (at least sometimes)
 - Marathon with a series of sprints
 - You will and should work hardest during the first couple of years.
 - Unlike college, there is always something you should be doing.
3. There will be a great deal of autonomy and flexibility that you are not used to.
 - Part of graduate school is developing skills as an independent scholar.
 - Important to keep a regular schedule and set goals as well as limits for yourself.
 - Keep track of projects and prioritize well.
 - Projects do not always have set deadlines, so you should set ambitious deadlines yourself.
4. With more autonomy, faculty often expect graduate students to be proactive.
 - Don't wait to be "told what to do", but also don't be afraid to ask for help.
 - As a new graduate student you will need to seek out information rather than being a passive recipient to information.
 - Reach out to faculty with potential research ideas and ask how you can help faculty push projects forward.
 - Don't be afraid of coming to faculty with "bad ideas" - we all have underdeveloped research ideas. The faculty are there to help you develop these ideas further!
5. By the end of graduate school you are expected to become an expert in something but also have a breadth of I/O psychology knowledge.
 - I want my graduate students to eventually be able to teach me things that I do not know!

What to do when you are in graduate school...

1. Develop a good work ethic early.
 - Matthew Effect - The rich typically get richer in graduate school programs.
 - Publishing takes at least a year, so be conscious of getting manuscripts out early in your graduate school tenure.

2. Be open to feedback from the faculty and your fellow graduate students. Remain in good communication with the faculty and your other graduate students.
3. Try to work with different people (e.g., faculty, graduate students).
 - You will learn different skills and perspectives working with different people.
 - Develop good relationships with others in the program.
 - Act as a mentor to more junior graduate students.
4. When you are working, work. When you are at play, play.
 - This seems obvious, but my graduate students and I struggle with this often.
 - Important to use your time wisely in graduate school, but also maintain a work-life balance.
 - You should take time off to focus on yourself and your relationships to avoid burnout.
5. Be strategic with the projects you take on.
 - Do not put all your eggs in one basket - will want to have multiple projects in process in hopes that one will develop into a good publication.
 - Do not spread yourself too thin. Be aware of your productivity limits.
 - *Finish* what you start.
6. You can say no to projects (particularly later in graduate school).
7. Prioritize what will ultimately get you a job (e.g., publications for academic focus/internships and research experience for applied focus) and what will ultimately allow you to graduate (e.g., finish that dissertation!).
8. Do not leave until you have finished your dissertation, or you might never finish.
9. Network with both faculty *and* graduate students. These will be your colleagues and hopefully collaborators.
10. Handle your finances well:
 - Save money throughout the year for summer.
 - Learn how to do your taxes.
 - Save money for unexpected occurrences (e.g., car trouble, computer crashing, friend's weddings).

Similar resources:

<http://hml.louistay.com/iopsych?p=how>

<http://www.siop.org/tip/oct11/07campion.aspx>